



ARGENTINES

NEW-WORLD NATION: OLD-WORLD CULTURE

the strongest European (as opposed to Amerindian) influence. This is due not only to early Spanish colonization, but

Land of diversity

South America's second largest country, Argentina has a hugely diverse population. As well as the Hispanic majority, there is a significant Italian sector here, and small, proud, pockets of French, Jewish, British, Japanese, and Polish people. The name Argentina comes from *argentum*, the Latin word for "silver"; early explorers mistakenly thought there were large deposits of the mineral here.



NATIONAL INSTRUMENT

Invented in 1830 and shaped like a large, square concertina, the *bandoneón*—an important element of tango culture—is Argentina's national instrument. Its name is believed to come from a combination of "Band," the last name of an important musical-instrument dealer of the day, with the word "acordeón" (accordion).

People who play this instrument are known as *bandoneonistas*.

TEATRO COLÓN



The glittering Teatro Colón in Buenos Aires is one of the world's finest opera houses. Since it was built in 1908, the leading opera and ballet stars of every generation have performed here—from Enrico Caruso to Plácido Domingo, and from Anna Pavlova to Mikhail Barishnikov.

TWO TO TANGO

Born in the slums of Buenos Aires near the turn of the 20th century, the slow and sensual dance called the tango has since taken the flavor of Argentinian life to almost every country in the world.



MODERN CITY

The wide Avenida 9 de Julio that runs through the heart of Buenos Aires was named in honor of Argentina's Independence Day. People who live in this huge waterfront city are known as *Porteños*—literally, "people of the port."